Masters in Business Administration (MBA)

Business Analytics (Tigers)

Batch 2025-27

EXISTENTIAL DIALOGUE

From Possession to Stewardship: What Aparigraha and Lokasamgraha Can Teach Modern Business

(Final Research Project)

Faculty

Prof Ananta Kumar Giri

Submitted By:

Harita C (25WU0204001)

Ashwitha Katta (25WU0202007)

Chintakayala Navya (25WU0202011)

Hari Priya Mahimaluru (25WU0202028)

Kalyan Kottem (25WU0202025)

Anuka Paul (25WU0202068)

Date: 12.11.2026

Introduction

Ask most people what a company is for and you'll hear some version of the same answer: it exists to make money. The idea is so familiar that it barely registers as an idea at all. But it is one, and it has consequences. A business that treats growth as the only measure of success will eventually run into the limits of the planet it draws from and the society it depends on. Floods, heat waves, widening inequality and a general loss of trust in big institutions are not separate stories. They are partly what that single answer looks like after a few decades of being followed.

This report takes the theme of existential dialogues literally. It asks what business is for, and what it means to live well alongside nature and other people. Instead of borrowing a framework from Western management theory, we look to two ideas from Indian thought: *aparigraha*, the practice of not holding on to more than one needs, and *lokasamgraha*, the commitment to holding the world together through one's work.

Our argument is simple. These ideas are not decoration. Where they shape who owns a company and how it sets its targets, they produce a different kind of business. Where they stay in the brochure, they change nothing. We test this through Tata and Godrej, two Indian groups that talk often about public purpose, and we look at where each falls short.

The ideas behind the argument

Aparigraha is usually translated as non-possession, but that undersells it. In the Yoga Sutras it sits among the basic ethical restraints, and the point is less about owning nothing than about refusing to grasp. You take what you need, hold it lightly, and don't build your identity around accumulating more. For a corporation, the nearest translation is probably sufficiency: asking how much extraction, expansion and profit is enough, rather than assuming the answer is always more.

Lokasamgraha comes from the Bhagavad Gita, where Krishna tells Arjuna that even someone with nothing left to achieve should keep acting for the sake of holding the world together. Work, in this reading, is not only a way to earn. It is how a person takes part in keeping society and nature going. The Gita pairs this with *nishkama karma*, acting without clinging to the fruits of the action, which matters when we get to the individual.

Gandhi's idea of trusteeship is where these ideas meet economics. He argued that wealthy people and business owners should see themselves as trustees of their wealth on behalf of

society, not as its masters. He wasn't asking for charity on the side. He was asking for a different relationship to ownership itself.

It helps to see how this differs from the usual Western framings. Shareholder primacy says a company's job is to maximise returns to its owners. ESG reporting and stakeholder models soften that with measurements and wider obligations, but they mostly keep profit as the organising goal and treat society and nature as constraints or risks to be managed. The Indian framework reverses the order. Society and nature are not external factors; the business sits inside them. Whether any real company behaves that way is the question for the next section.

The corporation: Tata and Godrej

Tata. Tata is the most cited example, and for good reason. The group's holding company, Tata Sons, is not controlled by a founding family or by public shareholders. Around 66% of its equity share capital is held by philanthropic trusts, which support causes including education, healthcare, livelihood generation, and art and culture (Business Today, 2026a). Most of that is held through the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and Sir Ratan Tata Trust, which together own about 51.54% (Outlook Business, n.d.). This is trusteeship written into the share register. The people at the top of the ownership chain are tied to a charitable purpose, which is about as close to *lokasamgraha* as a balance sheet gets.

The structure has also been tested. In 2026 a boardroom dispute broke out around the chairman's reappointment and the question of listing Tata Sons. One director, Noel Tata, voted against the resolution, and the Trusts later challenged the validity of the decision (Outlook Business, n.d.). Noel Tata's broader argument is that charitable ownership has allowed the group to combine commercial goals with long-term institution-building, and he fears that listing could change that character (Open Magazine, n.d.). Commentators have pointed out that ownership does not automatically translate into unified control (Business Today, 2026b). This is the most interesting part of the case. The structure protects purpose on paper, but purpose still has to be defended by real people, in real rooms, who disagree with each other. It also raises a quieter point about trusteeship itself. A trustee is accountable to a purpose rather than to personal gain, but purposes need interpreting, and two trustees can read the same purpose differently. Gandhi's model assumed good judgment; it did not promise agreement.

Godrej. Godrej & Boyce approaches the same question from the operating side. Its Good & Green vision, launched more than a decade ago and aligned with the UN Sustainable

Development Goals, rests on employability, innovating Good & Green products, creating a greener India, and shared value through community development (Godrej & Boyce, 2021).

What makes it more than a slogan is that it has numbers attached. In 2020 the company joined EP100, committing to double its energy productivity and cut carbon intensity by 60% by 2030 (Godrej & Boyce, n.d.-a). Business India reported that it had invested ₹500 crore in these initiatives over the previous decade (Joseph, 2023), and it has since set a goal of drawing half its revenues from its Good & Green portfolio by 2032 (Outlook Planet, n.d.).

The link here is to *aparigraha* more than *lokasamgraha*: the discipline of doing more with less. Doubling energy productivity is sufficiency expressed in engineering terms. Still, we should be careful. "Good & Green" is the company's own category, and the revenue share it reports depends on how the company defines the label. Self-reported figures, however impressive, are not an independent audit.

The self: leaders and individuals

Corporate philosophy sounds abstract until it lands on one person at 11 pm with an inbox still open. Hustle culture rests on a quiet belief: that more output, more hours and more visibility are always better, and that you are only as valuable as your last result. That is *aparigraha* violated at a personal level, a grasping for status and achievement with no natural stopping point. Burnout is what happens when the grasping outlasts the person.

Nishkama karma offers a different footing. It does not mean not caring about results or not working hard; the Gita is emphatic about doing one's duty fully. It means doing the work well without letting the outcome decide your worth. Someone who works this way can lose a deal, miss a promotion or watch a project get cancelled without feeling that the self has gone with it. That is a healthier base for a career than the constant comparison most of us know too well. None of this is a call to give up ambition. The older texts are not anti-work. They ask what the ambition is attached to, and whether it can survive a bad quarter.

For leaders the stakes are higher. People who decide how much a company extracts and how much it leaves behind are also making a statement about sufficiency in their own lives. A leader who cannot say "enough" personally will find it hard to build a company that can. The cases above suggest that restraint at the top shapes restraint in the firm, though we can't prove which way the cause runs.

Nature and society

In the Indian framework, nature is not a resource a business draws on but something the business sits inside. That sounds poetic, but it has practical consequences. If a company is a guest in an ecosystem, waste becomes a debt rather than a line in the cost sheet. Circular models, where products are designed to be reused, repaired or recycled, stop looking like special projects and start looking like ordinary good manners. Godrej's own language links its targets to decarbonisation, energy efficiency and the promotion of a circular economy (Godrej & Boyce, n.d.-b), which fits this pattern, even if the proof is in the delivery. The interesting cases are the ones where good economics and good ethics pull apart, such as when a greener material costs more or a cheaper process is dirtier. Saving energy is easy to defend because it helps the budget as well as the planet. Those other moments are when sufficiency has to beat convenience.

On the social side, India has written part of this idea into law. Under Section 135 of the Companies Act, 2013, companies above certain size thresholds must spend 2 percent of their average net profit on CSR (Ministry of Corporate Affairs, 2013). Whether you read that as *lokasamgraha* made mandatory or as a tax by another name depends on how the money is spent. At its best, CSR funds work that markets would not, in education, health and livelihoods. At its worst it becomes a reporting exercise. The Tata model avoids some of that tension because philanthropy is not a percentage taken off profits at year end. It is built into who owns the company.

The social question underneath all of this is trust. People are tired of firms that promise a lot about purpose and deliver little. Companies that tie their purpose to ownership and measurable targets give people something to check, and that is where trust starts to be rebuilt.

Critical reflection

None of this is a success story with a few footnotes.

First, there is the gap between philosophy and practice. Philosophical language is easy to borrow and costs nothing, which makes it attractive for branding. A company can talk about stewardship while its supply chain stays as extractive as ever. The real test is whether the idea constrains a decision, for instance by turning down a profitable project, and the public record rarely shows that. The Godrej targets are also long-dated. A 2030 or 2032 goal is easy to

announce and hard to hold anyone to, so the real judgement belongs to whoever reads the progress reports in those years.

Second, scale. Tata and Godrej are both old, family-rooted groups with unusual ownership histories. Their models may not translate to a listed company facing quarterly earnings, or to a start-up funded by venture capital. The 2026 Tata dispute shows that even the structure we admire is under pressure, including from regulatory communication that pushed the group to look for a lawful alternative to listing (Outlook Business, n.d.).

Third, these traditions are plural and contested. *Aparigraha* is a personal ethic from a tradition that leans towards renunciation. Applying it to a corporation is an interpretation, not a settled fact, and a critic could say we are stretching the concept to fit the cases. We think the stretch is defensible, but it is a stretch, and honest research should say so.

Finally, much of our evidence is company-reported or comes from the press. A fuller study would look at independent audits, employee experience and community outcomes.

Conclusion

We began with the habit of answering "what is a company for?" with "profit" and asked whether older Indian ideas give a better answer. Our finding is a qualified yes. *Aparigraha* and *lokasamgraha* did not make Tata or Godrej immune to conflict or contradiction, but they gave both groups something to build around: a trust-based ownership structure in one case, and concrete efficiency and revenue targets in the other. In both, the philosophy is visible because it has been turned into structure or numbers.

For the self, the lesson is the same in smaller form. Sufficiency and detached effort are not about doing less. They are about knowing what the work is for. For nature, the shift is from owning to being accountable. For society, it is from promising to being checkable.

A report can't close the existential question the theme raises. Companies will meet it again every time a profitable option collides with a responsible one. What we can say is that the idea of "enough" is no relic. It may be the more practical idea in a world running out of room to ignore it.

References

- Business Today. (2026a, August 13). *Tata Sons succession: Who controls Tata Group's holding company and how it operates*. https://www.businesstoday.in/latest/corporate/story/tata-sons-succession-who-controls-tata-groups-holding-company-and-how-it-operates-548970-2026-08-13
- Business Today. (2026b, September 22). *Who controls Tata Sons? Why Tata Trusts' 66% stake does not tell the whole story*. https://businesstoday.in/latest/corporate/story/who-controls-tata-sons-why-tata-trusts-66-stake-does-not-tell-the-whole-story-557097-2026-09-22
- Easwaran, E. (2007). *The Bhagavad Gita* (2nd ed.). Nilgiri Press.
- Godrej & Boyce. (2021, October 19). *Godrej & Boyce adopts ambitious ESG goals to create value* [Press release]. https://godrejenterprises.com/Resources/uploads/InnerPress/PressReleaseGBadoptsambitiousESGgoals1_20122049.pdf
- Godrej & Boyce. (n.d.-a). *Godrej & Boyce aims to have 30% of its y-o-y revenues come from Good & Green products* [Press release]. https://godrejenterprises.com/press-release-good-and-green-products
- Godrej & Boyce. (n.d.-b). *Godrej & Boyce commits to smarter energy use, joins the EP100 global business revolution* [Press release]. https://godrejenterprises.com/press-ep100
- Joseph, L. (2023, June 12–25). Pioneering progress: Godrej & Boyce achieves its 'good & green' vision. *Business India*. https://magzter.com/stories/business/Business-India/PIONEERING-PROGRESS
- Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Government of India. (2013). *The Companies Act, 2013*, Section 135 (Corporate social responsibility). https://www.mca.gov.in
- Open Magazine. (n.d.). *L'Affaire Tata: More questions than answers*. https://openthemagazine.com/business/laffaire-tata-more-questions-than-answers
- Outlook Business. (n.d.). *Tata Trusts' 66% stake in Tata Sons masks a tighter voting battle*. https://www.outlookbusiness.com/corporate/tata-trusts-66-stake-in-tata-sons-masks-a-tighter-voting-battle
- Outlook Planet. (n.d.). *Godrej & Boyce unveils ambitious 2032 sustainability targets*. https://planet2.outlookindia.com/news/godrej-boyce-unveils-ambitious-2032-sustainability-targets-news-416442
- Satchidananda, S. (2012). *The Yoga Sutras of Patanjali*. Integral Yoga Publications.